

Resources Institute," he adds. The buildings will have sewage treatment facilities, solar heating panels and rain water harvesting systems. Another argument put forward by activists is that the site is a groundwater recharge zone. Half of Delhi's water needs are met from groundwater. The floodplain is also located in a seismic zone.

Since 1948, the land around the riverbed had been leased to small farmers. But with the city expanding, land grabbers soon began eyeing what was a prime area on the eastern fringes of the city. DDA made a key change in

nent structures should be built on the riverbed, revised its opinion this year, based on documents supplied by DDA, which said that a bund built in 2000 to prevent floodwaters from reaching the Akshardham temple had redefined the river's floodplain.

Environmentalists, however, do not agree. "MOEF has been cajoled into granting the clearance. In the guise of creating infrastructure, kickbacks are given to private parties," says an activist, on condition of anonymity. Indeed, according to former minister for sports Mani Shankar Aiyar, the

green space, housing training areas for athletes). The riverbed in Delhi measures 4,500 hectares," he says.

To suggestions that the area near the Safdarjung airport, Dwarka or Jasola be used as alternative sites for construction, Mukherjee says the site should be centrally located. The Safdarjung area serves as a helipad for the President, prime minister and other VIPs. Another factor in favour of the present site is that the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium and Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium are located close by.

Says green crusader Diwan Singh,

QAMAR SIBTAIN



AREA OF CONTENTION: A signboard for the site, near Akshardham temple

	FIRST STAND	VOLTE FACE
MoEF	It had recommended a ground-water study, which was never undertaken. In December 2006, it gave DDA permission for temporary structures only.	In April 2007, MOEF issued a clearance, allowing the construction of permanent structures on the Yamuna riverbed.
NEERI	In a 1999 report, it had said that no permanent structures should be built on the riverbed, a position it confirmed in 2005.	NEERI has revised its opinion this year, based on DDA documents that claim that a bund built in 2000 has redefined the river's floodplain.
DDA	According to DDA, the proposed land-use for the site of the Games Village was for an 'agriculture and water body'.	The 2021 Master Plan changed the proposed land-use description for the Village to 'residential' and 'land for commercial projects'.

"People are free to protest. But it acts as a deterrent to good work."

SHEKHAR DEY, DDA PROJECT INCHARGE FOR THE COMMONWEALTH GAMES

land-use for the site in its 2021 Master Plan, changing the description of the proposed site for the Village from 'agriculture and water body' to 'residential' and 'land for commercial projects'.

In November 2006, the Union Ministry of Environment and Forests (MOEF) had recommended a ground-water study in the area, which was never undertaken. In December, it had given DDA the permission to construct only temporary structures so that the riverbed could be restored after the Games. But in April 2007, MOEF issued an environmental clearance allowing the construction of permanent structures on the site. The National Environmental Engineering Research Institute (NEERI), which, in its 1999 report to DDA, had said that no perma-

lands allocated for infrastructure for the Games total Rs 6,400 crore. Another Rs 20,000 crore will be spent on improving the existing facilities in the city. A June 2007 Assocham report estimates a revenue of Rs 4,500 crore will be generated by the Games, boosting Delhi's economy by 49 per cent.

Dey says that DDA took clearances from 17 bodies before constructing the Village. "In China, most of the work for the Beijing Olympics is complete. That's because decisions are taken by one apex body," he says. Ranjan Mukherjee, officer on special duty to the lieutenant-governor, Delhi, says environmentalists are not concerned about the space crunch in Delhi. "Construction is being carried out on 61 hectares (of which eight will be

of Yamuna Satyagraha and Natural Heritage First, "The Games are for 10 days and the river is for ever, so it's essential to plan keeping in mind our scarce resources." Adds noted urban planner K.T. Ravindran: "The Games should have been treated as an opportunity to improve walkways, monuments, venues and pedestrian networks, but the focus has been on the Games Village."

While there are laws against pollution, there's no law that protects rivers as an ecosystem, which is probably why they are the most abused. The green crusaders are ready to take the matter to the Supreme Court, even as construction continues and the Yamuna remains an unfortunate launchpad for our lofty ambitions. ■